

Canterbury vs. Wisteria

A structural read of two California Life Plan communities against the Windsor benchmark — where the money actually goes, what the fee sheets don't say, and the one clause that matters more than every price on either page.

SOURCES: 2026 FEE SCHEDULES, BOTH COMMUNITIES CANTERBURY EFF. 07·01·2026
WISTERIA EFF. 02·01·2026

BOTTOM LINE

Given that one spouse is expected to need care soon, **the contract structure is worth more than the entrance-fee difference** — and the two communities are not structured the same way. Wisteria is a Type A Life Care contract, where the monthly fee stays roughly flat if a resident moves into assisted living or memory care. Canterbury's own sheet offers a **5% discount** in Assisted Living, the Courtyard and Care Suites — which is fee-for-service with a courtesy discount, not life care.

On a realistic memory-care scenario, that single difference runs \$80,000–\$105,000 per year in Canterbury's disfavor. It overwhelms the roughly \$250,000–\$300,000 Canterbury saves on the way in. **If the spouse who needs care can pass Wisteria's health underwriting, Wisteria is the better structure for this family.** If she cannot — and Type A communities underwrite hardest precisely because they carry the care risk — that decision gets made for you, and Canterbury becomes the answer by default.

Everything below is the evidence for that, plus the eleven things I'd want answered in writing before anyone signs.

Three premises that don't survive the fee sheets

CORRECTION

The house sale does not pay for this "in perpetuity"

It pays the *entrance fee*. That is the smaller number. The entrance fee buys the right to occupy and the care promise; it does not prepay the monthly fee, which runs for the rest of both lives and rises every year. You've said the monthly is covered by the annuity, Social Security and book royalties — good, and that removes the near-term problem. It does not remove the long-term one, which I model in the escalation section: monthly fees in this sector typically climb 4–6% a year, while a fixed annuity climbs 0% and royalties usually decline. Those lines diverge.

CORRECTION

At a \$1.2M ceiling, Wisteria has no 1,700 sq ft option

Every Wisteria floor plan at or near 1,700 sq ft starts above your maximum. Sycamore (1,604–1,734 sq ft) starts at \$1,439,360. Heritage Oak (1,619) starts at \$1,439,360. Birch (1,653) starts at \$1,725,360. Against a \$1,200,000 ceiling, the realistic Wisteria unit is roughly **1,225–1,360 sq ft** — about 300–475 sq ft less than the Windsor apartment, a 20–28% reduction in floor area.

CORRECTION

Neither community offers a two-car garage

Nothing in either document shows private garages. Wisteria is a six-story mid-rise; the floor plans show decks with exterior storage closets, not garages. Canterbury's plans show decks and balconies. Both will have resident parking, but a two-car garage attached to the residence is not part of either product. If the garage is where the workshop, the boxes and the second car live, that capacity has to be replaced — and at Wisteria the deck storage closet is what's on offer.

Ask both: how many parking spaces per residence, garage or surface, assigned or not, included or extra — and what separate storage is available and at what monthly cost?

The Windsor benchmark, and what actually compares

Your reference point is **1,700 sq ft, two bedrooms, two-car garage**, with a \$20,000–\$30,000 deposit already placed at Windsor. I've matched on interior square footage and bedroom count, since neither community can match the garage.

One gap I couldn't close

I could not identify which "Windsor" this is from the materials provided — there are several unrelated senior communities in California using that name. That matters for two reasons: whether your \$20–30k deposit is *refundable* (most priority-reservation deposits are, minus a processing fee, but some become non-refundable at contract signing), and whether Windsor is even a Life Plan/CCRC community at all or a straight rental. **Tell me which Windsor and I'll fold it in as a true third column** — including whether walking away from that deposit costs you anything.

Wisteria at Warner Center — options within your \$900k–\$1.2M range

WISTERIA • 2026 SCHEDULE • TWO-BEDROOM PLANS • REPAYABLE ENTRANCE FEE					
FLOOR PLAN	CONFIGURATION	SQ FT	ENTRANCE FEE	MONTHLY FROM	VS. BUDGET
Extended Willow	2 bed / 2 bath	1,225–1,234	\$1,044,160–\$1,101,360	\$7,801	FULL RANGE FITS
Willow	2 bed / 2 bath	1,160–1,425	\$929,760–\$1,402,960	\$7,682	LOWER HALF ONLY
Juniper	2 bed / 2 bath	1,161–1,360	\$888,160–\$1,278,160	\$7,682	LOWER HALF ONLY
Grand Willow	2 bed / 2 bath / den	1,312–1,744	\$1,044,160–\$1,668,160	\$8,039	BOTTOM OF RANGE ONLY
Pacific Willow	2 bed / 2 bath	1,518–1,573	\$1,397,760	\$8,522	OVER
Sycamore	2 bed / 2 bath	1,604–1,734	\$1,439,360–\$1,626,560	\$8,156	OVER
Heritage Oak	2 bed / 2 bath / 2 den	1,619	\$1,439,360–\$1,626,560	\$8,156	OVER
Birch	2 bed / 2 bath / den	1,653	\$1,725,360–\$1,787,760	\$8,039	OVER
Woodland	2 bed / 3 bath / den	1,827–1,933	\$1,652,560–\$1,824,160	\$8,691	OVER

Closest true match within budget: Extended Willow. It's the only plan whose *entire* price range sits inside your ceiling, which means you aren't fighting for the one remaining ground-floor unit. Layout is a genuine two-bedroom split — Master 12×15, second bedroom 12×13, living 14×15, in-unit washer/dryer, deck with exterior storage. **Grand Willow at its floor price** (\$1,044,160, 1,312 sq ft) is the alternative: same money, ~80 sq ft more, and you gain a den — but at the bottom of a range that tops out at \$1,668,160, so you are by definition buying the least desirable exposure in that plan.

Read the price spread as a floor-and-view map

Willow spans \$929,760 to \$1,402,960 — a 51% swing for the same floor plan. That spread is almost entirely floor level and view. The units at the bottom of each range are the ground-floor, interior-facing, or least-desirable-exposure homes, and in a filling community they are the first to go. **Any quote you're given needs a specific unit number attached**, or you're comparing a price that may not be available.

The Canterbury — two-bedroom options

Canterbury's fee sheet discloses no square footage — anywhere

Both pricing pages and both floor plans omit it entirely. For a community asking \$670,000–\$872,000 to walk in, that is a conspicuous omission, and it makes the comparison you asked for impossible to do precisely. The figures below are **my estimates**, derived from the room dimensions printed on the floor plans plus normal allowances for kitchen, closets, circulation and wall thickness. Treat them as ±10% and **demand the real numbers in writing**.

CANTERBURY · PRICES EFFECTIVE 1 JULY 2026 · BOTH CONTRACT CHOICES				
FLOOR PLAN	EST. SQ FT	CHOICE 1 · 80% REPAYABLE	CHOICE 2 · 36-MO AMORTIZED	MONTHLY
Ladera	~1,000 EST	\$670,843–\$741,459	\$436,048–\$481,948	\$7,853
La Venta	~1,100 EST	\$723,516–\$795,868	\$470,286–\$517,315	\$8,292
Mira Costa	~1,400 EST	\$792,974–\$872,271	\$515,433–\$566,976	\$8,584
Riviera	~1,500 EST	\$839,279	\$545,532	\$8,874
Hermosa	1 bedroom	\$385,489–\$471,153	\$250,568–\$306,250	\$6,981

Closest match: Mira Costa — bedrooms of 16'4"×11'6" and 14'3"×15', a 11'4"×23'6" living room, two full baths (one of them 11'×11'6", which is unusually generous and matters if a walker or wheelchair is coming), a pantry, in-unit washer/dryer and two balconies. It is the largest genuine two-bedroom on the sheet apart from Riviera. Notably, **the whole Canterbury two-bedroom range fits inside the \$950,000 house proceeds even on the fully repayable contract** — you would be buying the top of their inventory, not the bottom.

HOW I ESTIMATED THE SQUARE FOOTAGE

Mira Costa: bedrooms 187.8 + 213.8 sq ft, living room 266.3, baths 126.5 + 54 = 848 sq ft of dimensioned space. Adding a kitchen (~120), pantry, closets (~80), entry and circulation (~90), then ~8% for wall thickness, lands near 1,400 sq ft. La Venta: bedrooms 192.7 + 140, living 233.3, baths 78.8 + 28.3 = 673 sq ft dimensioned; with kitchen, dressing area, closets and circulation, roughly 1,100. Ladera and Riviera are inferred from their price positions relative to those two, since no plans were provided for either — which is itself worth noting: **you were shown plans for two of the four two-bedroom units.**

Against the Windsor benchmark

SPACE COMPARISON · 1,700 SQ FT TWO-BEDROOM BENCHMARK				
OPTION	SQ FT	VS. WINDSOR	GARAGE	ENTRANCE FEE
Windsor (benchmark)	1,700	—	2-car	\$20–30k deposit placed
Wisteria · Extended Willow	1,225–1,234	–28%	None	\$1,044,160–\$1,101,360
Wisteria · Grand Willow (base)	1,312	–23%	None	\$1,044,160
Canterbury · Mira Costa	~1,400 EST	–18%	None	\$792,974–\$872,271
Canterbury · Riviera	~1,500 EST	–12%	None	\$839,279

On space per dollar, Canterbury wins clearly: roughly 1,400–1,500 estimated sq ft for \$793k–\$872k against Wisteria's 1,225–1,312 sq ft for \$1.04M–\$1.10M. **That is the entire case for Canterbury, and the next section is why it may not be enough.**

The clause that decides this

You told me one spouse is independent and one is likely to need care within a few years. That fact makes the care-cost clause the most valuable line item in either contract — worth multiples of the square footage, the view, or the entrance fee spread.

Wisteria — Type A (Life Care)		Canterbury — discount, not life care	
STRUCTURE	Type A life care contract	STRUCTURE	Sheet states 5% discount in Assisted Living, the Courtyard and Care Suites
ON MOVING TO HIGHER CARE	Monthly fee stays substantially the same	ON MOVING TO HIGHER CARE	You pay 95% of the prevailing rate, on top of the independent-living fee for the remaining spouse
CARE ON SITE	Assisted living, memory care and skilled nursing in an adjacent health center	CARE ON SITE	Assisted living and memory care; skilled nursing needs verification (see below)
EFFECT	The community absorbs the cost of long-term care. That risk transfer is the product.	EFFECT	The family retains essentially all of the care-cost risk.

What that difference costs, modelled

Assume the scenario you described: one spouse moves into memory care, the other stays in the two-bedroom. Los Angeles County memory care in 2026 realistically runs \$9,000–\$13,000 a month at a community of this calibre; I'll use \$11,000 as the midpoint.

MONTHLY COST ONCE ONE SPOUSE ENTERS MEMORY CARE		
COMPONENT	CANTERBURY (MIRA COSTA)	WISTERIA (EXTENDED WILLOW)
Independent living, remaining spouse	\$8,584	\$7,801
Second-person fee	– (drops off)	\$2,583
Memory care, at market less discount	\$10,450 \$11,000 LESS 5%	Included under Type A
Total per month	≈ \$19,034	≈ \$10,384
Difference per year	≈ \$103,800 in Wisteria's favour	

Across a five-year memory-care episode — which is a normal duration, not a pessimistic one — that gap is roughly **\$400,000 to \$520,000**. Canterbury's entrance-fee advantage over Wisteria is about \$250,000–\$300,000. **The care structure is worth more than the entire price difference, and it reverses the ranking.**

Two things that would change this conclusion

One: if Canterbury's Residence & Care Agreement turns out to contain a genuine life-care or modified (Type B) benefit that the marketing sheet compressed into the words "5% discount," the gap narrows sharply. The sheet is a summary, not the contract. Verify against the actual agreement.

Two: Type A pricing at Wisteria already embeds the care risk — that is part of why the entrance fee is higher and why the monthly fee is what it is. You are not getting the care free; you are buying insurance. The question is whether this particular couple, with a known near-term care need, is a good buyer of that insurance. **Given the facts you've described, they are almost the textbook case for it.**

And the gate on all of it: health underwriting

Type A communities underwrite health and finances hardest, precisely because they are assuming the care liability. A prospective resident with an existing dementia diagnosis or significant care needs may be **declined for independent living, required to enter assisted living directly at a different price, or offered a modified contract that strips the life-care benefit** — which would eliminate the entire advantage above. This needs to be established before you spend another hour on floor plans.

Ask Wisteria first, in writing: given this specific diagnosis and care profile, does she qualify for the standard Type A contract in independent living – and if not, what exactly is offered instead, and at what price?

Canterbury's two contracts: which one

Canterbury offers the same apartments under two entrance-fee structures. Same monthly fee either way — the only variable is what comes back.

MIRA COSTA • CONTRACT COMPARISON AT THE LOW END OF EACH RANGE		
	CHOICE 1 • 80% REPAYABLE	CHOICE 2 • 36-MONTH AMORTIZED
Paid in	\$792,974	\$515,433
Extra cash required	\$277,541	—
Returned after 3+ years	\$634,379 (80%)	\$0
Net cost of the entrance fee	\$158,595	\$515,433

Recommendation: Choice 1, the 80% repayable contract. The reasoning is a break-even against what that extra \$277,541 would earn if invested instead:

- At a 6% alternative return, the opportunity cost of the extra capital reaches the \$634,379 repayment at roughly **year 14**. Below that, Choice 1 wins; beyond it, Choice 2 edges ahead.
- For a **short stay** Choice 1 wins decisively — Choice 2 amortizes to zero at month 37, so an unexpected death or move in year four forfeits the entire \$515,433.
- Given that one spouse already faces a near-term care need, a stay beyond 14 years is not the base case. **Choice 1 is the better expected outcome and the far better estate outcome.**

The caveat that undoes this: Choice 1's advantage depends entirely on the 80% actually being *paid*. That is the subject of the next section, and it applies to both communities.

The repayment problem nobody advertises

Both communities market a large refund. Canterbury calls it an **"80% Re-occupancy Benefit."** Wisteria calls it a **"Repayable Entrance Fee."** Read both names literally — the money is conditioned on the unit being re-occupied or resold, and neither sheet states a date certain.

This is a known and active problem in California. The legislature has addressed it twice. **SB 939**, effective 2017, forces interest to accrue on unpaid repayments — 4% after 180 days from vacancy, 6% after 240 days, compounding annually thereafter — and requires providers to make a good-faith effort to re-occupy. Critically, it also requires contracts to disclose **the average and the longest time the provider has taken to resell a unit over the last five calendar years**. That disclosure is your single best diagnostic, and you are entitled to it.

AB 1983 is moving through the legislature right now, and it targets Wisteria's model

AB 1983 (Rubio, 2025–26 session, passed the Senate committee stage as of June 2026) expands the definition of a "repayable contract" to cover fees repaid **"based on the sequential order in which repayable contracts are terminated"** — that is, a queue. Under a queue model your estate is not waiting for *your* unit to resell; it is waiting for everyone ahead of it in line to be paid first. The fact that the legislature is writing a bill specifically about this practice tells you how often it goes wrong.

Ask both, in writing: is repayment triggered by resale of my specific unit, or by position in a queue? What were the average and longest repayment times in the last five years?

Wisteria cannot answer that question, and that is the point

Wisteria opened in 2025 and is still filling 486 residences. It has **no five-year resale history to disclose**, because it has no history at all. Your estate's repayment would depend on the resale market for a large, brand-new, still-filling community — and on Wisteria's cash position during fill-up, which is the most capital-hungry phase of a CCRC's life. Canterbury, at 187 licensed beds and decades of operation, can produce a real track record. **Make it.**

Who you'd actually be trusting

An entrance fee is an unsecured bet on an operator staying solvent for twenty years. The two operators here are structurally different in ways that matter.

Canterbury — Episcopal Communities & Services		Wisteria — Spieker Senior Development Partners	
TYPE	Not-for-profit, founded 1923	TYPE	Privately held, for-profit , owned by Warren "Ned" Spieker Jr.
CREDIT	Fitch A–, stable outlook , affirmed December 2024	CREDIT	No public credit rating . Financial disclosure comes only through the CDSS annual filing.
PORTFOLIO	The Canterbury (Rancho Palos Verdes), The Covington (Aliso Viejo), MonteCedro (Altadena), plus affordable housing	PORTFOLIO	Six California CCRCs including La Costa Glen, Reata Glen, Stoneridge Creek, The Glen at Scripps Ranch, University Village. Reports full occupancy and wait lists across them.
METRICS	Operating ratio 89.6% against a Fitch 'A' median of 95.2% — better than peer. Occupancy above 90%.	TRACK RECORD	Strong on development and fill-up. Wisteria itself opened 2025 — no operating history for care quality .
FAITH	Episcopal-affiliated; states it serves people of all faiths. Sheet lists spiritual programs among amenities.	FAITH	Secular
REPUTATION	≈4.1–4.5 stars across aggregators; US News "Best Senior Living" for both assisted and independent living; repeated local "South Bay's Best" awards	REPUTATION	4.8 stars / 33 Google reviews — but read with care (below)
SETTING	Coastal Rancho Palos Verdes, small (187 licensed capacity), ocean views	SETTING	Warner Center, Woodland Hills. 17 acres, six storeys, 486 residences. Inland valley heat.

MATERIAL

Wisteria's glowing reviews are reviews of the sales process

The praise that recurs is for "residency counselors" and the clarity of the admissions conversation. Those are sales staff. A community that opened in 2025 has not yet been tested on the thing you're actually buying — night-shift staffing in memory care, responsiveness when someone falls at 3am, whether the skilled nursing wing is adequately covered. **Four-point-eight stars on a sales experience predicts very little about clinical care.** Canterbury's reviews, by contrast, cover decades of actual operation, and they are more mixed — some families raise concerns about consistency of nursing skill mix and responsiveness. Mixed reviews of real care are more informative than perfect reviews of a tour.

MATERIAL

A California appellate court let a Spieker/Continuing Life community bill residents for its own legal costs

In *Johnson v. Stoneridge Creek Pleasanton CCRC LLC*, a resident sued the community, owner Spieker Senior Development Partners and operator Continuing Life over alleged violations including the Consumer Legal Remedies Act and the Elder Abuse Act, and challenged the community passing anticipated litigation costs to residents through fee increases. **The appellate court held the Health & Safety Code permits a CCRC to include "reasonable projections" of litigation expense in monthly fees.** Residents can therefore fund the defence of claims brought against the community — including their own neighbours' claims. This is now settled California law and applies across the sector, but it is live precedent involving this specific ownership group.

Ask Wisteria: is Continuing Life LLC the operator here, and does the monthly fee methodology include projected legal expense?

WATCH

Staffing signals — thin, but worth naming

Employee reviews for Continuing Life LLC average about 3.6/5 with 68% recommending, and include direct complaints of high turnover among lower-paid staff and heavy micromanagement. That population — caregivers, dining, housekeeping — is exactly the group whose churn residents feel daily. For ECS the public employee data is unreliable: search results conflate it with several unrelated "Episcopal Community Services" organisations, so **I would not put weight on any ECS turnover figure you find online.** Ask each community directly for caregiver turnover in the last 12 months and the current agency-staffing percentage. A community that won't answer has answered.

Hidden fees and disclosure gaps

Canterbury

DEALBREAKER

Is there actually skilled nursing on site?

The licence printed on Canterbury's own materials is **RCFE 191603774** — a Residential Care Facility for the Elderly, which is California's assisted-living licence, not a skilled nursing licence. The amenity list says "24-hour on site Licensed Nurses," which is not the same thing as a licensed skilled nursing facility. Third-party marketing sites assert Canterbury offers skilled nursing, but those aggregators are frequently wrong. **If there is no on-site SNF, then long-term nursing care means leaving the campus** — at LA County market rates of roughly \$12,000–\$16,000 a month, uncapped and undiscounted, at exactly the moment the family is least able to manage a move.

Ask: is there a CDPH-licensed skilled nursing facility on this campus? Licence number, bed count, and current CMS star rating.

MATERIAL

One meal a day, for a fee of \$8,584 a month

The included dining is "one meal per day." For a couple who eat mostly in the dining room, the other two meals each, at \$15–25 per meal, run roughly **\$1,800–\$3,000 a month** on top. That is a real and recurring cost that appears nowhere on the fee sheet. It is partly offset by full kitchens in the apartments — but the spouse in declining health is the one least likely to cook.

MATERIAL

Prices already re-cut once this year

The sheet reads "Prices effective July 1, 2026" — six weeks old at the time of writing. Neither the size nor the frequency of past increases is disclosed anywhere.

Ask: the last ten years of monthly fee increases, as percentages, year by year.

WATCH

Smaller line items

\$750 processing fee for the personalized nursing assessment. Telephone and internet excluded from the monthly fee — every other utility is included. Second person \$1,250/month. Floor plans were supplied for only two of the four two-bedroom units (La Venta and Mira Costa); Ladera and Riviera were priced but not shown.

MATERIAL

The monthly fee on the sheet can legally be 10% higher

Footnote one: *"Estimated monthly fees may be up to 10% higher for premium priced homes."* The column is also headed **"Monthly Service Fee Starting At"** — a floor, not a price. So Extended Willow's \$7,801 could be \$8,581, an undisclosed \$780 a month, or \$9,360 a year. And "premium priced homes" is undefined.

Ask: for this specific unit number, what is the exact monthly fee – not the starting-at figure?

MATERIAL

Second person costs \$49,000 up front plus \$2,583 a month

More than double Canterbury's \$1,250 second-person fee, plus a \$49,000 entrance charge Canterbury doesn't levy at all. Over ten years the second-person difference alone is roughly \$209,000. This is the price of the Type A benefit extending to both spouses — it is not unreasonable, but it must be in the comparison. There is a footnote that *"pre-construction deposits not subject to Second Person Entrance Fee"*; you have no pre-construction standing, so assume the \$49,000 applies, but it is worth one question.

MATERIAL

"Repayable" has no percentage attached anywhere on the sheet

The column says "Repayable Entrance Fee" and nothing else. Public materials suggest at least 75%; the contract may say 75%, 80% or 90%. On a \$1,044,160 entrance fee, the difference between 75% and 90% is **\$156,624**. That number is not on the page you were handed.

WATCH

The reservation-of-rights clause, and fill-up risk

Footnote: *"Wisteria reserves the right to change product design, options, prices, fees and terms without prior notice."* Standard language, but combined with a community still filling 486 units it deserves attention: if fill-up runs slow, the pressure lands on fee increases and on the repayment queue. Also confirm the adjacent health centre is **licensed, open and staffed today** — not a later phase. A Type A promise is only as good as the building that has to honour it.

Both

DEALBREAKER

The \$950,000 is not \$950,000

Selling the house triggers capital gains. With the \$500,000 married-couple exclusion and a long-held California home with a low basis, the taxable gain can still be substantial. On a \$950,000 sale with, say, a \$150,000 basis: \$800,000 gain, less the \$500,000 exclusion, leaves \$300,000 taxable. At federal long-term rates plus the 3.8% net investment income tax plus California income tax, that is plausibly **\$70,000–\$100,000 gone** — so the real proceeds are nearer **\$850,000–\$880,000**. That is the difference between clearing Canterbury's Mira Costa comfortably and not clearing it at all.

Get the actual adjusted basis from their CPA before committing to any number.
Improvements over the decades raise basis and reduce the bill.

MATERIAL

An entrance fee is not a house, and the tax treatment differs sharply

They are converting an appreciating asset with a stepped-up basis at death into a contract right that does not appreciate, cannot be borrowed against, generates no mortgage interest deduction, and carries no Proposition 13 protection. That may well be the right trade for the care and the freedom from maintenance — but it should be a decision, not a surprise.

On the other side of the ledger: **Type A contracts are the ones that qualify for the prepaid-medical-expense deduction**, typically 30–40% of the non-refundable portion of the entrance fee and of monthly fees, subject to the 7.5%-of-AGI threshold, and claimable only in the year paid. Wisteria's Type A structure likely qualifies. Canterbury's, if it is genuinely a 5%-discount fee-for-service arrangement, likely does not — which quietly widens the real cost gap further in Wisteria's favour. **Confirm with their CPA; this is worth real money and is routinely missed.**

MATERIAL

What happens if the money runs out

Neither sheet addresses it. Most nonprofit CCRCs maintain a benevolence or resident-assistance fund and commit not to evict a resident who exhausts their assets in good faith; for-profit operators are less likely to. As a nonprofit with a century-old charitable mission, ECS is the more likely of the two to have such a policy in writing. Ask both — and get the answer from the contract, not the tour guide.

WATCH

Geography is a real variable here

Rancho Palos Verdes and Woodland Hills are roughly 45 miles and, in Los Angeles traffic, 60–90 minutes apart. One is coastal and temperate; the other is inland valley, where summer routinely exceeds 100°F. Canterbury is small and intimate at 187 beds; Wisteria is 486 residences on 17 acres with an indoor pool, theatre, performing arts centre, pickleball and bocce. **Which one the family can actually visit weekly for the next fifteen years is not a soft factor** — visit frequency is among the better predictors of care quality outcomes, because someone is watching.

The slow problem: fee escalation

You've said the monthly fee is covered by the annuity, Social Security and book royalties. For today, that's true. The issue is that these four lines move at different speeds.

ANNUAL MONTHLY-FEE BURDEN AT 5% ESCALATION · COUPLE, TWO-BEDROOM		
YEAR	CANTERBURY · MIRA COSTA	WISTERIA · EXTENDED WILLOW
Today	\$118,008	\$124,608
Year 5	\$143,500	\$151,500
Year 10	\$183,200	\$193,300
Year 15	\$233,800	\$246,700
Year 20	\$298,400	\$314,900

Against that: **a fixed annuity rises 0%**. Social Security rises with COLA, historically around 2.5%. Book royalties, absent new titles, decline — backlist income typically decays rather than compounds. A fee growing at 5% against income growing at 1–2% blended produces a gap that opens slowly and then suddenly.

The two questions this raises

Is the annuity fixed or inflation-adjusted? If fixed, model the crossover year — the point where the fee exceeds covering income — and make sure there is a reserve sized to bridge from there. **And what is each community's actual increase history?** 5% is my assumption, not their disclosure. Ten years of actual percentages, from both, in writing. A community that has averaged 3% is a materially different proposition from one that has averaged 6.5%, and neither sheet says a word about it.

Get these eleven answers in writing before anyone signs

01 **Wisteria, first and before anything else:** given her specific diagnosis and care needs, does she qualify for the standard Type A contract in independent living? If not, what is offered instead and at what price? This gates the entire decision.

02 **Canterbury:** the exact square footage of Ladera, La Venta, Mira Costa and Riviera — plus floor plans for Ladera and Riviera, which you were priced on but never shown.

03 **Canterbury:** is there a CDPH-licensed skilled nursing facility on campus? Licence number, bed count, CMS star rating. If not, what is the plan when nursing-home-level care is needed?

04 **Canterbury:** what exactly does the Residence & Care Agreement provide on higher levels of care beyond the 5% discount? Is there any fee cap, any lifetime benefit, any Type B modified provision?

05 **Both:** the exact repayment percentage, the repayment trigger — resale of my unit, or queue position — and the average and longest repayment times over the last five years, which SB 939 requires you to disclose.

06 **Both:** ten years of monthly fee increases, year by year, as percentages.

07 **Wisteria:** for this specific unit number, the exact monthly fee, not the "starting at" figure. Confirm whether the 10% premium-home uplift applies.

08 **Both:** parking — spaces per residence, garage or surface, assigned, included or extra — and available separate storage with monthly cost.

09 **Both:** caregiver turnover over the last twelve months, and current percentage of shifts filled by agency staff.

10 **Both:** the written policy if a resident outlives their assets. Benevolence fund, non-eviction commitment, or neither.

11 **Both:** the most recent audited financial statements and the CDSS annual disclosure. For Wisteria specifically, current occupancy and the fill-up schedule for all 486 residences.

And one for your own side

Have their CPA confirm the adjusted basis on the house and model the actual after-tax proceeds, and confirm whether the entrance fee at the chosen community qualifies for the prepaid-medical-expense deduction. Those two answers can move six figures. Also determine whether the Windsor deposit is refundable — you may be holding an option worth keeping while this plays out, or a sunk cost worth writing off today.

Where I land

If she qualifies for Type A: Wisteria, Extended Willow. You give up roughly 175 estimated square feet and pay roughly \$250,000 more going in, and in exchange you transfer the care-cost risk to the community at precisely the moment this family is about to need it. On the modelled memory-care scenario that trade pays for itself in under three years and keeps paying. The right unit is Extended Willow rather than Grand Willow's base price, because Extended Willow's full range fits your ceiling — you are choosing among units rather than taking the last one.

If she does not qualify: Canterbury, Mira Costa, Choice 1. Roughly 1,400 estimated square feet for \$792,974–\$872,271 against a house that nets perhaps \$850,000–\$880,000 after tax — it fits, on the repayable contract, buying near the top of their inventory rather than the bottom. A Fitch A– nonprofit with a century of operating history and a real local reputation is a genuinely safer counterparty than an unrated for-profit still filling its first building. Then budget separately and honestly for market-rate care, because that contract will not cover it.

What would change my mind: Canterbury's actual Residence & Care Agreement containing a real life-care benefit that the marketing sheet buried, or a confirmed on-site skilled nursing facility with good CMS ratings. Both are checkable. Both are on the list above.

The thing I'd want said plainly

The premise this started from was that the house sale settles the question and cost isn't a worry. On these documents, cost isn't the worry — **structure is**. Two communities separated by about \$250,000 on the way in are separated by roughly \$100,000 *a year* on the way through, in the opposite direction, and none of that appears on either page you were handed. That asymmetry, not the price of the apartment, is the decision.

Prepared from the two 2026 fee schedules supplied (Canterbury, effective 1 July 2026; Wisteria at Warner Center, effective 1 February 2026) plus public sources on operators, regulation and reputation. Square footage for Canterbury is estimated from printed room dimensions because the community discloses none — treat as $\pm 10\%$ pending written confirmation. Memory-care, tax and escalation figures are modelled on stated assumptions, not quotes. Nothing here substitutes for the Residence & Care Agreement, the CDSS annual disclosure, or advice from the family's CPA and an elder-law attorney.